

GAME CHANGERS

GOALS

IN THIS UNIT, YOU WILL:

- Read about the benefits of playing games online.
- Learn about how online gamers could help save the world.
- Explore ways to solve problems with games.

THINK AND DISCUSS

1. Do you play games online? What are some online games people play?
2. Why do you think online gaming is popular?



Gamers – people who play interactive games online – test a new online game at the E3 Electronic Entertainment Expo in Los Angeles, U.S.A.

Lesson A

PRE-READING

- A.** Read the caption at the top of page 53. What skills do you think you need to be successful in a game like this? Discuss your ideas with a partner.

Answers will vary. Successful players are often quick to react, smart strategists, and good collaborators.

- B.** Look at the infographic on page 54 and answer the questions below.

1. What does the infographic tell you about the number, type, and location of gamers in the world?

1.2 billion gamers worldwide; 700 million online gamers;
Western Europe and North America have the largest groups of
active gamers.

2. What information surprises or interests you?

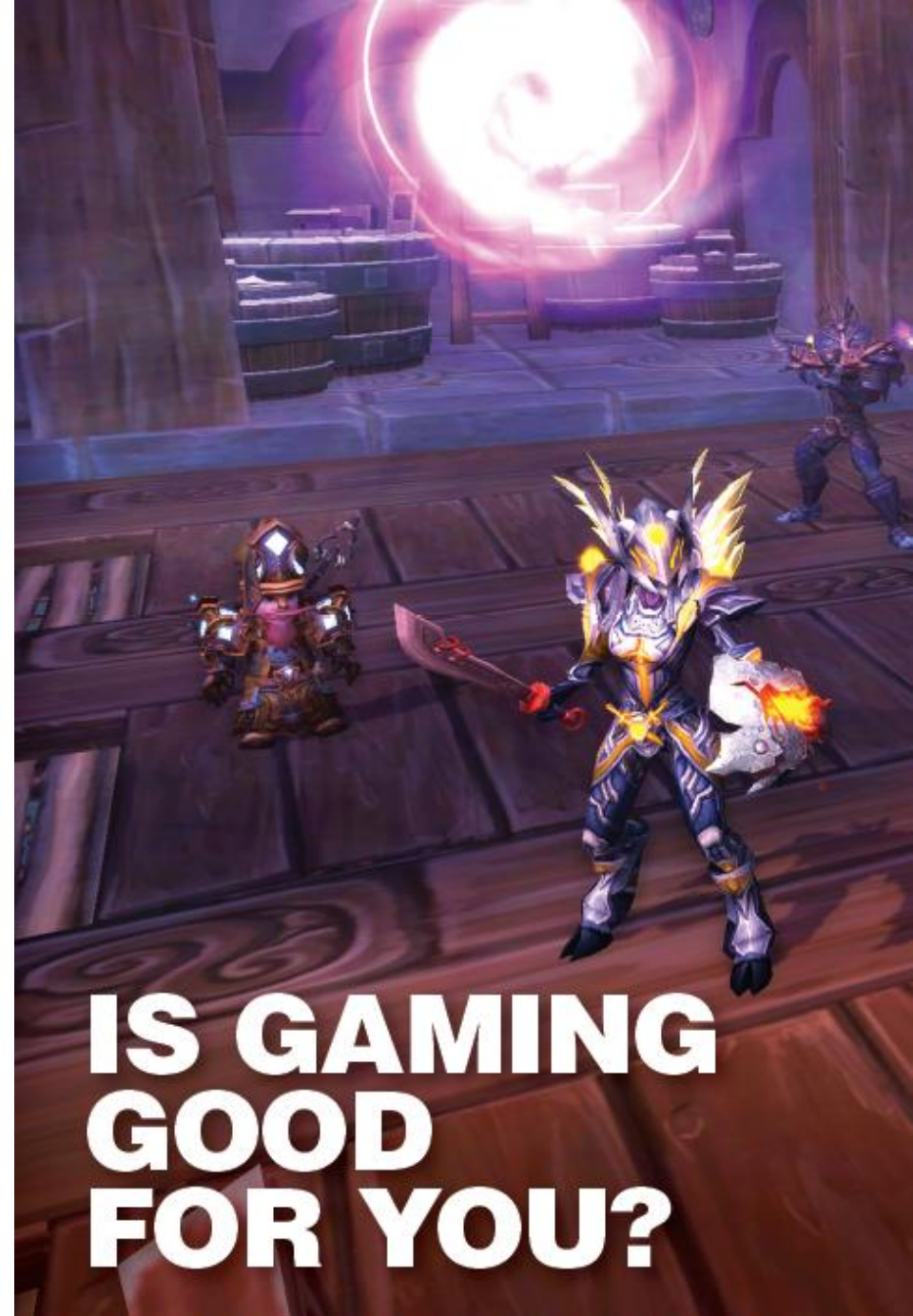
Answers will vary.

- C.** Look at the title of the passage. How would you answer the question in the title? Discuss with a partner.

Answers will vary.

- D.** Now skim the whole passage quickly. Does Jane McGonigal think online gaming is good for us?

Yes. McGonigal thinks the skills that gamers exhibit while playing games can be useful for solving world problems.





A screen shot of the multiplayer online game *World of Warcraft*. Gamers control an avatar and interact with other avatars during the game.



IS GAMING GOOD FOR YOU?

An “epic win”—winning a game in a way that seems impossible until it happens—is a great feeling. But can it help gamers solve real-world problems?

Researchers who study online gaming have shown that it is more than just a **form** of entertainment. In fact, people may benefit from online gaming in a number of ways. For example, multiplayer online gaming can improve social skills because players have to work together toward the same goals. In one study, researchers in the Netherlands surveyed teens who played *World of Warcraft*. They found that the more frequently most teens played, the more socially successful and less lonely they felt.

Online gaming may also improve thinking skills. In a recent study in Berlin, adults played a video game every day for two months.



Afterwards, researchers scanned the players' brains. They noticed that the players had more neurons in the parts of the brain that are responsible for memory and planning.

Game designer Jane McGonigal has her own ideas about the benefits of gaming—not just for individual people, but for the whole world. She calls people who play online games for at least one hour a day “virtuoso” gamers. Currently, there are about 500 million virtuoso gamers in the world. McGonigal predicts that in ten years there will be 1.5 billion.

McGonigal believes that these gamers have four **characteristics**—“superpowers”—that make them better problem solvers. These characteristics are:

- Urgent optimism: Online gamers don't wait to defeat a dragon. Instead, gamers face any problem immediately—and believe that they can succeed.
- Community builders: Players in an online game have the same goal—to win. They expect that everyone will play fairly and follow the same rules. This helps players build trust and improve **cooperation**.



- Blissful productivity: Gamers enjoy working hard to **achieve** online gaming goals. They feel a real sense of **accomplishment** when they do achieve these goals—the “epic win” feeling.
- Epic meaning: Gamers like being **involved** in an important mission. The larger-than-life worlds of online gaming make players feel that they are playing a part in a **significant** story.

Non-gamers may think online gaming is a waste of time and money. Some have argued online games contribute to problems like childhood obesity. However, McGonigal thinks online gamers could be an important global **resource** if we can design games that help them create “epic wins” in response to real-world problems.

GAMING BY THE NUMBERS



1.2 BILLION the number of gamers playing worldwide. Of these, 700 million are online gamers.



22 HOURS the average time a gamer plays *World of Warcraft* each week in the U.S.A.



70 BILLION DOLLARS the amount of money gamers spent in 2013



of gamers in the
U.S.A. are under
the age of 18

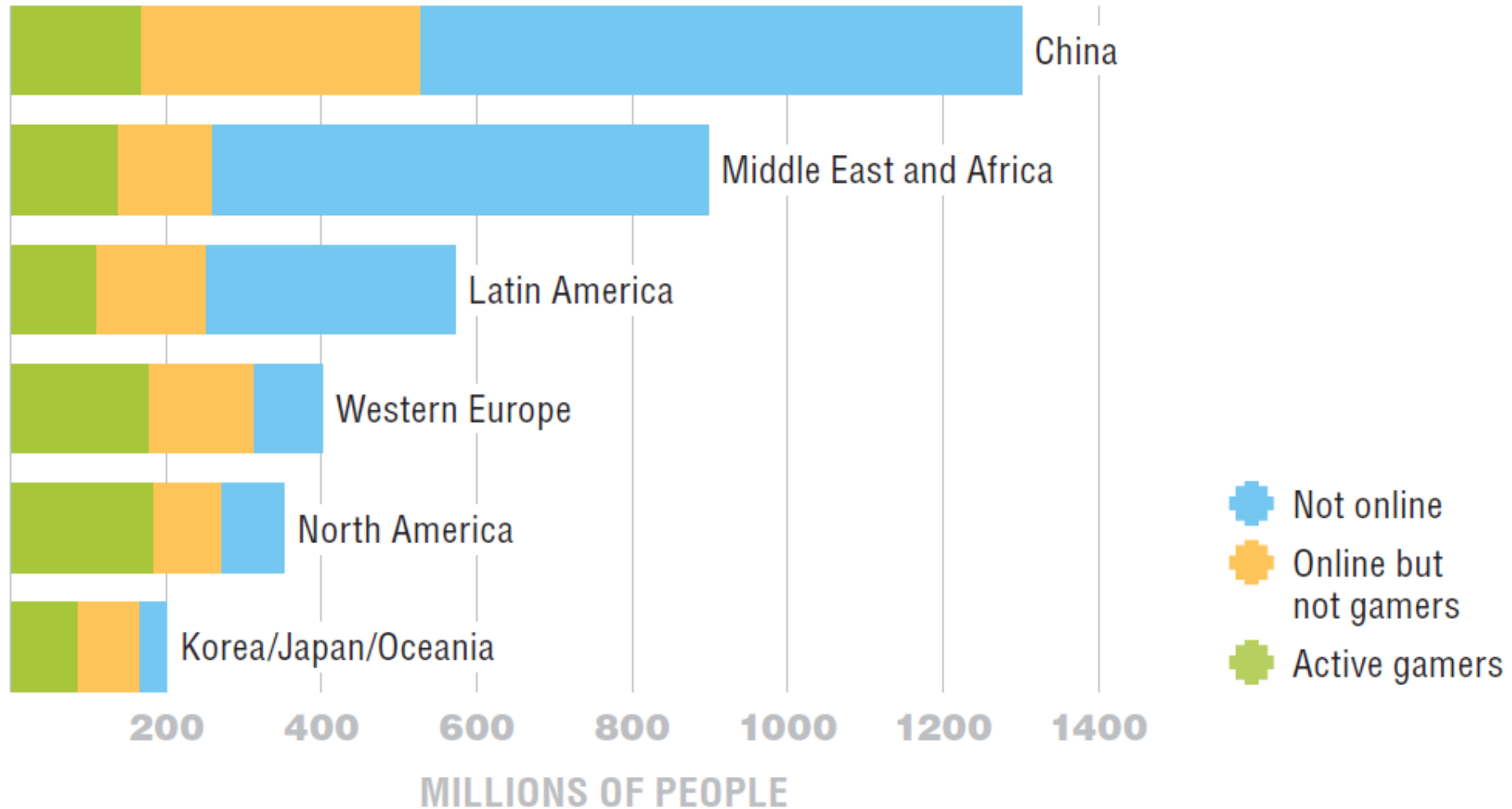


of gamers in the
U.S.A. are female



of parents in the U.S.A.
play games with their
children every week

ACTIVE GAMERS VS. TOTAL POPULATION



Sources: Jane McGonigal; 2013 Global Games Market Report; internap.com



Jane McGonigal shows a photo of a gamer reacting to an “epic win” while playing an online game. McGonigal thinks we can design games that help create epic wins in response to real-world problems.

Developing Reading Skills

GETTING THE MAIN IDEAS

Use information from the passage on pages 52–54 to answer each question.

1. How might multiplayer online gaming improve social skills?

Players work together toward the same goal. They also feel socially acceptable and less alone.

2. What two parts of the brain do some researchers think are improved by playing online games?

memory and planning

3. What particular group of gamers does McGonigal think is great at solving problems?

virtuoso gamers (those who play more than one hour every day)

UNDERSTANDING KEY DETAILS

Read the statements about virtuoso gamers below, and label them *T* for True or *F* for False based on the information in the passage.

- T 1. Virtuoso gamers can solve problems.
- T 2. Virtuoso gamers are prepared to work hard to get an epic win.
- T 3. Players often build trust with each other.
- T 4. Gamers can create a community that shares the same goals.
- F 5. Virtuoso gamers expect easy wins.

ANALYZING PROS AND CONS

To show a balanced approach, writers sometimes present both sides of an issue in their writing—the arguments for (the pros) and the arguments against (the cons).

A. Scan the passage and complete the chart with the possible pros and cons of online gaming.

Pros	Cons
1. Improves <u>social/thinking skills</u>	4. Waste of <u>time/money</u>
2. Improves <u>thinking/social skills</u>	5. Waste of <u>money/time</u>
3. Better <u>problem solvers</u>	6. Contributes to childhood <u>obesity</u>

B. Do you think the focus of the article is more about the positive side of online gaming, or the negative side? Discuss your answers with a partner.

The article focuses mostly on the positive side, only offering negative points at the very end, which have already been disputed in the main content.

UNDERSTANDING DATA

Look at the infographic on page 54 and answer the questions.

1. What percentage of U.S. gamers are under 18 years old?

18 percent

2. On average, how many hours a week does a gamer spend playing *World of Warcraft* in the U.S.A.?

22 hours

3. Which two regions of the world have the highest number of active gamers?

North America and Europe

4. Which part of the world has the most people online?

China

5. Approximately how much money did people spend on gaming worldwide in 2013?

\$70 billion

6. Did anything in the data surprise you? Discuss with a partner.

Answers will vary.

BUILDING VOCABULARY

A. Choose the best word to complete each sentence.

characteristics

involved

predict

significant

1. McGonigal thinks that virtuoso gamers have certain characteristics that make them good at online gaming.
2. The challenges of online games, such as saving the world from aliens, can make gamers feel like they are doing something significant.
3. Some researchers find that players who are involved in multi-player games develop stronger social skills.
4. Experts predict that online gaming will continue to increase in popularity in the next ten years.

B. Choose the best option(s) to answer each question.

b, c 1. Which of these are **resources**?

a. arguments

b. oil

c. water

c 2. Which of these activities requires **cooperation**?

a. taking an exam

b. reading a book

c. playing soccer

b, c 3. Which of these events are **accomplishments**?

a. speaking to a friend

b. winning a race

c. graduating from college

a, c 4. Which of these are usually **forms** of entertainment?

a. a TV show

b. a movie director

c. a pop song

GETTING MEANING FROM CONTEXT

The writer mentions the “larger-than-life” worlds of online games. What do you think “larger than life” means? What makes online gaming worlds larger than life?

extraordinary; a person or experience that is better and more
exciting than most

CRITICAL THINKING

1. **Inferring.** Why do you think more adults play video games now than they did in the past?

Answers will vary. Games have become more advanced and complicated, which likely attracts an older audience. And as the first generation of gamers gets older, they continue to play games as adults.;

2. **Reflecting.** What other activities do you think can improve a person's social skills? What activities might improve a person's memory? What activities might improve problem-solving skills?

Answers will vary.

EXPLORE MORE

Read more about game designer Jane McGonigal at TED.com. Share what you learn with the class.



GAMING CAN MAKE A BETTER WORLD

JANE MCGONIGAL Game designer, TED speaker

We spend 3 billion hours a week playing online games, but game designer Jane McGonigal thinks this isn't enough. In fact, she thinks that we should be playing online games for at least 21 billion hours a week for the next ten years.

For over ten years, McGonigal has been designing online games. She wants to convince more people to spend more time playing bigger and better games. Why? She believes that playing online games might help us solve global problems like poverty, climate change, and obesity.

In this lesson, you are going to watch segments of McGonigal's TED Talk. Read the information about McGonigal above and answer the questions.

1. How often does McGonigal think we should be playing online games?
She thinks that collectively we should spend 22 billion hours a week for ten years
2. What kinds of problems does McGonigal think online games can help solve?
global problems like poverty, climate change, and obesity

McGonigal's **idea worth spreading** is that the skills we learn playing games can also be used to solve real-world problems.



PART 1

SOLVING REAL-WORLD PROBLEMS

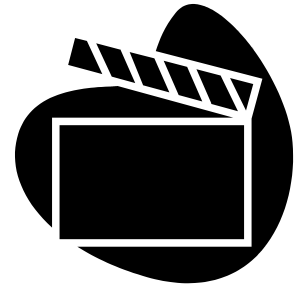
PREVIEWING

Read this excerpt from McGonigal's talk. What problem does she think a lot of gamers have? Note down your answers. Then discuss with a partner.

“And this is a problem that a lot of gamers have. We feel that we are not as good in reality as we are in games. And I don't mean just good as in successful, although that's part of it. We do achieve more in game worlds. But I also mean good as in motivated to do something that matters, inspired to collaborate and to cooperate.”

Gamers struggle to bring the same motivation that they have in online games to their work in the real world.

GETTING THE MAIN IDEAS



- A.** Watch (▶) the first segment of McGonigal's talk. Why does McGonigal think we don't often have an "epic win" face in real life?

Gamers don't believe they are as good at solving real-life problems as they are with problems in games. We give up quickly after failing, but in the game world we keep trying.

- B.** Check (✓) the feelings that McGonigal thinks do not exist in game worlds.

angry	✓overwhelmed	✓anxious	✓depressed
✓frustrated	tired	✓cynical	bored

C. Read the excerpt from McGonigal's talk and complete the sentence below.

“And the only problem is that [gamers] believe that they are capable of changing virtual worlds and not the real world. That's the problem that I'm trying to solve.”

McGonigal wants to help gamers change Answers will vary. Possibilities include: the way they approach real-world problems; their motivation in the real world; their attitude about failure in real life.

CRITICAL THINKING

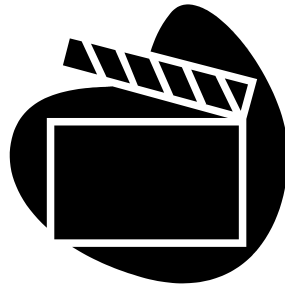
Inferring. What do you think McGonigal means when she says, “We do not want to try to predict the future. What we want to do is make the future”?

She wants online games to influence how we behave and act in the world. She wants games to shape a new world by getting gamers to solve current major problems.

EPIC WINS IN THE REAL WORLD

SUMMARIZING

Watch (▶) the second segment of McGonigal's talk. Complete the concept map with details about two of the three games that McGonigal describes.





Problem

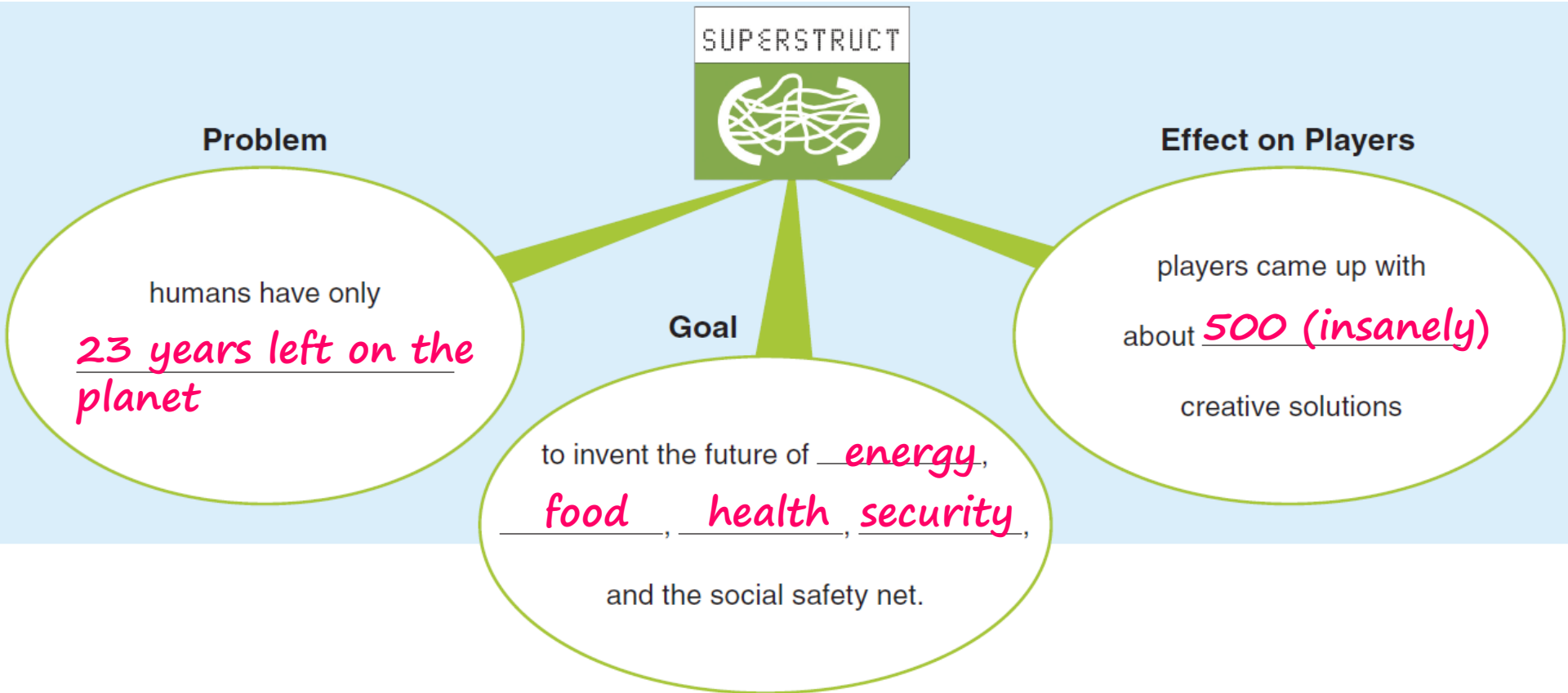
the world has run out of
/a shortage of oil

Goal

to survive a(n) oil shortage

Effect on Players

many players keep
habits
they learned playing the game



RECOGNIZING TONE AND MESSAGE

Read the excerpt from McGonigal's talk. Which statement below best matches McGonigal's message?

"I want to ask a question. What do you think happens next? We've got all these amazing gamers, we've got these games that are kind of pilots of what we might do, but none of them have saved the real world yet. Well, I hope that you will agree with me that gamers are a human resource that we can use to do real-world work, that games are a powerful platform for change. We have all these amazing superpowers: blissful productivity, the ability to weave a tight social fabric, this feeling of urgent optimism, and the desire for epic meaning."

weave a social fabric: v. to create a community

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weave a social fabric: v. to create a community

- ☒ 1. Games and online gamers provide a resource that could help us create the kind of world we want to live in.
- ☐ 2. Gamers like to work hard, are optimistic and cooperative, and share the feeling that they are doing something important.
- ☐ 3. Gamers have already shown that they can solve big, real-world problems.

CRITICAL THINKING

1. **Reflecting.** Would you like to play *World Without Oil* or *Superstruct*? Why or why not? Write your answer and then discuss with a partner.

Answers will vary.

2. **Evaluating.** Do you agree that gamers have “superpowers” and are a resource that we can use to solve problems? Write your answer and then discuss your reasons with a partner.

Answers will vary.

EXPLORE MORE

Watch McGonigal’s full TED Talk at TED.com. Learn more about why McGonigal thinks online game players are such good problem solvers. Share what you learn with your class.

Project



Project

- A. Work with a partner. You and your partner have been hired by the Institute for the Future to come up with a proposal for an online game that can have a positive impact on the world.**

You need to decide:

- on a global issue. Some ideas include reducing climate change, fighting epidemics, producing enough food for everyone, improving education, disaster relief, dealing with resource shortages (water, oil, trees, etc.), and so on.
- the game's end goal; how the game works; what do gamers need to do?
- the title of the game.

Project

B. Work with two other pairs.

- Give your presentation. Explain your proposal.
- As you listen, take notes.
- At the end, review your notes.
- Which proposal is the most likely to receive funding from the Institute for the Future?

EXPLORE MORE

Learn more about online gaming. Read “10 online games . . . with a social purpose” on the TED Blog at TED.com. What are some other games that help people think about big, real-world problems? How do you play them? Share your information with the class.

Part 1

. . . This picture pretty much sums up why I think games are so essential to the future survival of the human species. Truly. This is a portrait by a photographer named Phil Toledano. He wanted to capture the emotion of gaming, so he set up a camera in front of gamers while they were playing. And this is a classic gaming emotion. Now, if you're not a gamer, you might miss some of the nuance in this photo. You probably see the sense of urgency, a little bit of fear, but intense concentration, deep, deep focus on tackling a really difficult problem.

. . . Now, unfortunately this is more of the face that we see in everyday life now as we try to tackle urgent problems. This is what I call the "I'm Not Good At Life" face, and this is actually me making it. Can you see? Yes. Good. This is actually me making the "I'm Not Good At Life" face. This is a piece of graffiti in my old neighborhood in Berkeley, California, where I did my PhD on why we're better in games than we are in real life. And this is a problem that a lot of gamers have. We feel that we are not as good in reality as we are in games.

And I don't mean just good as in successful, although that's part of it. We do achieve more in game worlds. But I also mean good as in motivated to do something that matters, inspired to collaborate and to cooperate. And when we're in game worlds I believe that many of us become the best version of ourselves, the most likely to help at a moment's notice, the most likely to stick with a problem as long as it takes, to get up after failure and try again. And in real life, when we face failure, when we confront obstacles, we often don't feel that way. We feel overcome, we feel overwhelmed, we feel anxious, maybe depressed, frustrated, or cynical. We never have those feelings when we're playing games, they just don't exist in games.

. . . Gamers are super-empowered, hopeful individuals. These are people who believe that they are individually capable of changing the world. And the only problem is that they believe that they are capable of changing virtual worlds and not the real world. That's the problem that I'm trying to solve.

. . Now, I know you're asking, "How are we going to solve real world problems in games?" Well, that's what I have devoted my work to over the past few years, at the Institute for the Future. We have this banner in our offices in Palo Alto, and it expresses our view of how we should try to relate to the future. We do not want to try to predict the future. What we want to do is make the future. We want to imagine the best-case scenario outcome, and then we want to empower people to make that outcome a reality. We want to imagine epic wins, and then give people the means to achieve the epic win.

Part 2

I'm just going to very briefly show you three games that I've made that are an attempt to give people the means to create epic wins in their own futures. So, this is World Without Oil. We made this game in 2007. This is an online game in which you try to survive an oil shortage. The oil shortage is fictional, but we put enough online content out there for you to believe that it's real, and to live your real life as if we've run out of oil. So when you come to the game, you sign up, you tell us where you live, and then we give you real-time news, videos, data feeds that show you exactly how much oil costs, what's not available, how food supply is being affected, how transportation is being affected, if schools are closed, if there is rioting, and you have to figure out how you would live your real life as if this were true. And then we ask you to blog about it, to post videos, to post photos.

We piloted this game with 1,700 players in 2007, and we've tracked them for the three years since. And I can tell you that this is a transformative experience. Nobody wants to change how they live just because it's good for the world, or because we're supposed to. But if you immerse them in an epic adventure and tell them, "We've run out of oil. This is an amazing story and adventure for you to go on. Challenge yourself to see how you would survive," most of our players have kept up the habits that they learned in this game.

So, for the next world-saving game, we decided to aim higher: bigger problem than just peak oil. We did a game called *Superstruct* at the Institute for the Future. And the premise was a supercomputer has calculated that humans have only 23 years left on the planet. This supercomputer was called the Global Extinction Awareness System, of course. We asked people to come online almost like a Jerry Bruckheimer movie. You know Jerry Bruckheimer movies, you form a dream team—you've got the astronaut, the scientist, the ex-convict, and they all have something to do to save the world.

But in our game, instead of just having five people on the dream team, we said, “Everybody’s on the dream team, and it’s your job to invent the future of energy, the future of food, the future of health, the future of security, and the future of the social safety net.” We had 8,000 people play that game for eight weeks. They came up with 500 insanely creative solutions that you can go online, if you Google *Superstruct*, and see.

So, finally, the last game, we’re launching it March third. This is a game done with the World Bank Institute. If you complete the game you will be certified by the World Bank Institute as a Social Innovator, class of 2010. Working with universities all over sub-Saharan Africa, and we are inviting them to learn social innovation skills. We’ve got a graphic novel, we’ve got leveling-up in skills like local insight, knowledge networking, sustainability, vision, and resourcefulness. I would like to invite all of you to please share this game with young people, anywhere in the world, particularly in developing areas, who might benefit from coming together to try to start to imagine their own social enterprises to save the world.

So, I'm going to wrap up now. I want to ask a question. What do you think happens next? We've got all these amazing gamers, we've got these games that are kind of pilots of what we might do, but none of them have saved the real world yet. Well, I hope that you will agree with me that gamers are a human resource that we can use to do real-world work, that games are a powerful platform for change. We have all these amazing superpowers: blissful productivity, the ability to weave a tight social fabric, this feeling of urgent optimism, and the desire for epic meaning.

I really hope that we can come together to play games that matter, to survive on this planet for another century. And that's my hope, that you will join me in making and playing games like this. When I look forward to the next decade, I know two things for sure: that we can make any future we can imagine, and we can play any games we want. So, I say: Let the world-changing games begin. Thank you.